

Irrational Distinct-Height Sums for Finite Prime Sets

*Running least common multiples, three-prime kernel rank, and a tail criterion for
Erdős Problem #269*

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ABSTRACT

For every finite set P of at least two primes, the sum of the reciprocals of the distinct running least common multiples of the P -smooth integers is irrational. Erdős asserted this in a 1973 letter that gives no proof. For two primes it follows from a Hecke–Mahler transcendence theorem. A rational value would make the scaled tails of the sum integers, so two tails that are close would be equal. The tails after a prime power t and after tp^n , for a good return n , are close, and their words of primes differ by rearranging short runs; a point of a torus lying on exactly two coordinate walls produces a run of two primes whose rearrangement changes the tail. The proof is an ordinary one, checked step by step by a second AI agent; it has had no human review. For $\{2, 3, 5\}$ a different proof, by five affine maps with disjoint images on dyadic blocks, is checked in Lean. The companion extends this finite-state method to every set of three primes at most 31 by exact computation; it fails for $\{2, 3, 5, 7\}$, where two different words of blocks have the same affine map. The same comparison of two tails proves that the sub-sum of the catalogue series over the powers of one prime is irrational. For three distinct primes the reciprocal running-LCM kernel has nonsingular minors of every order, so no finite sum of products separates one exponent from the other two. For the repeated $\{2, 3, 5\}$ series, which counts a running LCM once for every integer at which it occurs, we prove a tail recurrence and a residue criterion equivalent to irrationality. Its tails grow quadratically, the finite-state argument has no counterpart there, and the criterion’s inequalities for every multiplier coprime to 30 after arbitrarily late starts are unproved.

1 Two sums from running least common multiples

The main result is the distinct-height irrationality theorem of Section 2. It applies to every finite prime set containing at least two primes. It does not settle the irrationality of the repeated-value series that motivated it. We introduce both sums here, keeping that distinction visible before the proof.

**Authorship and AI use.* Will Cook built and directed the research infrastructure and reviewed the claims when he could. AI agents did most of the research and drafting. Cook did not independently verify every claim.

For a finite prime set P , let $\mathcal{S}_P$ consist of the positive integers whose prime factors lie in P , including 1. We use $\mathbb{N} = \{0, 1, 2, \dots\}$ for exponent indices. For $x \geq 1$, put

$$L(x) = \text{lcm}\{u \in \mathcal{S}_P : u \leq x\}, \quad \mathcal{R}_P = \sum_{u \in \mathcal{S}_P} L(u)^{-1}.$$

Erdős asked whether $\mathcal{R}_P$ is irrational when $|P| \geq 2$ [1, p. 65][2, p. 106]. For $P = \{p, q, r\}$, write

$$H(x) = p^{\lfloor \log_p x \rfloor} q^{\lfloor \log_q x \rfloor} r^{\lfloor \log_r x \rfloor}, \quad K(i, j, k) = H(p^i q^j r^k)^{-1}.$$

Prime-power divisibility gives $L = H$ (Proposition 5.1). The running LCM is therefore constant between consecutive prime powers p^n, q^n, r^n ($n \geq 1$), and at each of them it is multiplied by the corresponding prime (Proposition 5.2). Counting each of its values once gives the *distinct-height sum*

$$\mathcal{D}_P = 1 + \sum_t H(t)^{-1},$$

where t runs over the prime powers p^n, q^n, r^n with $n \geq 1$. The two sums differ because the running LCM repeats: 5 and 6 both have running LCM 60, which contributes $2/60$ to $\mathcal{R}_{\{2,3,5\}}$ and $1/60$ to $\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}}$. In a letter dated 1 January 1973, Erdős called the irrationality of $\mathcal{R}_P$ a conjecture he could not prove and wrote that he could show the distinct-height sum to be irrational; the letter prints no argument [3]. Erdős and Graham state only the question for $\mathcal{R}_P$ [1, p. 65], and we have not found a proof in print (the companion's Section 11.1 lists the sources searched). Section 2 proves the irrationality of $\mathcal{D}_P$ for every finite P with $|P| \geq 2$.

Fan used the identity $L = H$ to separate the two-prime kernel [7]. With three primes, even a finite sum of separated products is impossible (Section 3). That theorem is about the kernel and says nothing about the arithmetic of its sum. Sections 5 and 6 turn to the repeated $\{2, 3, 5\}$ sum and state exactly what its irrationality still requires.

Formal proofs. A result with a kernel-checked Lean proof carries a mark in the margin. *Lean* opens the proof: the declaration itself when one declaration states the whole result, otherwise the list of declarations that together state it. *Comparator* opens the record of an independent check, in which the same statement, written again from Mathlib alone in a separate repository, was compared with our proof by Lean's Comparator tool, allowing only the three standard axioms. A dagger on the Lean mark means that the Lean proof assumes an input named just below the result. A result without a mark has no Lean proof of its whole statement; what is checked is said below it. The [evidence record](#) gives every declaration, version and check. These checks show that the stated propositions are proved; whether they are the right propositions is a question the reader can settle by comparing them with the text.

2 Irrationality for finite prime sets

Let P be a finite set of primes with $|P| \geq 2$ and put $H_P(t) = \prod_{r \in P} r^{\lfloor \log_r t \rfloor}$. The proof of Proposition 5.1 applies to any finite set of primes: the running LCM of the P -smooth integers up to t is $H_P(t)$, and it changes only at the prime powers r^n ($r \in P, n \geq 1$),

where it is multiplied by r . List these prime powers as $t_1 < t_2 < \dots$, let q_k be the prime of t_k , and put $Q_k = q_1 \cdots q_k = H_P(t_k)$. Then

$$\mathcal{D}_P = 1 + \sum_{k \geq 1} \frac{1}{Q_k}.$$

For $P = \{2, 3, 5\}$ the prime powers $2, 3, 4, 5, 8, 9, 16, 25, 27, 32, \dots$ carry the heights $2, 6, 12, 60, 120, 360, 720, 3600, 10800, 21600, \dots$, so $\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}} = 1.7796169832947490504 \dots$

Theorem 2.1 (the distinct-height sums). *For every finite set P of primes with $|P| \geq 2$, the number $\mathcal{D}_P$ is irrational.*

Ordinary proof, outlined below and given in full in the companion, Section 4.1. It was found within this project on 26 September 2026 and checked step by step by a second, independent AI agent, whose five small corrections are incorporated; it has had no human review. It has no Lean proof, so Comparator does not apply. The case $P = \{2, 3, 5\}$ is Theorem 2.6, which is checked in Lean.

For $|P| = 2$ the theorem is contained in Theorem 4.1: $\mathcal{D}_{\{p,q\}}$ is an affine function of one Hecke–Mahler value, which is transcendental by Loxton and van der Poorten [6, Theorem 8, p. 40] and Bugeaud and Laurent [5, Theorem 1.1]. For $|P| \geq 3$ every Hecke–Mahler theorem we found has a single slope.

The proof compares two tails of the series. A rational value makes every scaled tail an integer, so two tails closer than the scale are equal. The tails after t_k and after $t_k p^n$, for a suitable n , are that close. Their words of primes differ only by rearranging short runs, and equality of the tails forces an integer invariant f to agree on each run and its rearrangement. A run of two primes violates this, and a point of a torus on exactly two coordinate walls produces one.

Words. For an infinite word $u = u_1 u_2 \dots$ over P put $V(u) = \sum_{i \geq 1} (u_1 \cdots u_i)^{-1}$. For a finite word $\sigma = \sigma_1 \cdots \sigma_n$ put $\Pi(\sigma) = \sigma_1 \cdots \sigma_n$ and

$$f(\sigma) = \sum_{t=1}^n \sigma_{t+1} \cdots \sigma_n,$$

the term $t = n$ being 1. Then $f(\sigma)$ is a positive integer and

$$V(\sigma u) = \frac{f(\sigma) + V(u)}{\Pi(\sigma)}. \quad (1)$$

Put $x_k = V(q_{k+1} q_{k+2} \dots) = \sum_{j > k} Q_k / Q_j$. Every suffix of $q_1 q_2 \dots$ contains every prime of P , in particular one larger than $\min P$, so its value lies in $(0, 1/(\min P - 1)) \subseteq (0, 1)$.

Lemma 2.2 (integral tails). *If $\mathcal{D}_P = N/K$ with integers N and $K \geq 1$, then Kx_k is an integer for every $k \geq 1$.*

Proof. $Q_k \mathcal{D}_P = Q_k + \sum_{i \leq k} Q_k / Q_i + x_k$, and Q_i divides Q_k for $i \leq k$. So $Kx_k = Q_k N - K(Q_k + \sum_{i \leq k} Q_k / Q_i)$. $\square$

Lemma 2.3 (rearranged blocks). *Let $u = \sigma_1 \sigma_2 \dots$ and $u' = \sigma'_1 \sigma'_2 \dots$ be infinite words, where each σ_i is a nonempty finite word and σ'_i is a rearrangement of it, and suppose that every suffix of u or u' starting at a block boundary has value in $(0, 1)$.*

- (i) If $V(u) = V(u')$, then $f(\sigma_i) = f(\sigma'_i)$ for every i .
- (ii) If $\sigma_i = \sigma'_i$ for every $i < i_0$, then $|V(u) - V(u')| < 1/\Pi(\sigma_1 \cdots \sigma_{i_0-1})$.

Proof. Let U_i and U'_i be the values of the suffixes starting at block i . Since $\Pi(\sigma_i) = \Pi(\sigma'_i)$, (1) gives $\Pi(\sigma_i)(U_i - U'_i) = f(\sigma_i) - f(\sigma'_i) + U_{i+1} - U'_{i+1}$. If $U_i = U'_i$, the integer $f(\sigma_i) - f(\sigma'_i)$ equals $U'_{i+1} - U_{i+1} \in (-1, 1)$, so both vanish. Induction from $U_1 = V(u) = V(u')$ proves (i). For (ii), $V(u) - V(u') = (U_{i_0} - U'_{i_0})/\Pi(\sigma_1 \cdots \sigma_{i_0-1})$. $\square$

Lemma 2.4 (short rearrangements). *The map f is injective on the orderings of any set of at most three distinct primes.*

Proof. For two primes, $f(ab) = 1 + b$. For three, $f(\sigma_1\sigma_2\sigma_3) = 1 + \sigma_3(1 + \sigma_2)$. Let σ, σ' be orderings of $\{a, b, c\}$ with $f(\sigma) = f(\sigma')$. If $\sigma_3 = \sigma'_3$, then $\sigma_2 = \sigma'_2$ and $\sigma = \sigma'$. Otherwise say $\sigma_3 = a$ and $\sigma'_3 = b$, so $a(1 + \sigma_2) = b(1 + \sigma'_2)$ with $\sigma_2 \in \{b, c\}$ and $\sigma'_2 \in \{a, c\}$. The pairs (b, a) and (c, c) give $a = b$, the pair (b, c) gives $b \mid a$, and (c, a) gives $a \mid b$. $\square$

For four primes injectivity fails: $f(5, 7, 3, 2) = f(7, 2, 3, 5) = 51$. The proof therefore looks for a run of two primes, for which $f(ab) - f(ba) = b - a \neq 0$.

The torus. Let $\mathbb{T} = \prod_{q \in P} \mathbb{R}/(\log q)\mathbb{Z}$ and $\Theta(s) = (s \bmod \log q)_{q \in P}$ for $s \in \mathbb{R}$. For $\theta \in \mathbb{T}$ a q -crossing is a real t with $\theta_q + t \in (\log q)\mathbb{Z}$, and $W(\theta)$ is the word of the primes of the positive crossings in increasing order of time. For $\theta_k = \Theta(\log t_k)$ the positive q -crossings are the times $\log(q^j/t_k)$ with $q^j > t_k$, so $W(\theta_k) = q_{k+1}q_{k+2} \cdots$, and crossings of different primes never coincide.

Let T_0 be the closure of $\Theta(\mathbb{R})$, a subtorus containing every θ_k . Every forward orbit $\{\theta + \Theta(t) : t \geq t_0\}$ with $\theta \in T_0$ is dense in T_0 , by Kronecker's theorem or a one-line pigeonhole argument (the companion's Section 4.1).

In the coordinates $\varphi_q = \theta_q / \log q$ the torus is $\mathbb{R}^P / \mathbb{Z}^P$, and by Kronecker's theorem T_0 is the image of the smallest rational subspace $L \subseteq \mathbb{R}^P$ containing $\omega = (1/\log q)_{q \in P}$. The annihilator of L is a rational subspace spanned by the integer vectors c with $\sum_q c_q / \log q = 0$. If it contained a nonzero vector supported on at most two primes a, b , it would contain an integer one, and $\log a / \log b$ would be rational, which is false because no power of a is a power of b . So each φ_q is nonzero on L and any two are linearly independent on L . In particular the linear form $\theta_b - \theta_a = (\log b)\varphi_b - (\log a)\varphi_a$ is nonzero on L , although it vanishes on the flow direction ω .

Lemma 2.5 (two walls). *If $|P| \geq 4$, there is $x \in T_0$ with $\theta_q(x) = 0$ for exactly two primes $q \in P$.*

The companion proves Lemma 2.5 (its Lemma 4.4) on a two-dimensional rational subtorus of T_0 , where the sets $\{\theta_q = 0\}$ are families of parallel closed geodesics, by an Euler-characteristic count on their arrangement.

Outline of the proof of Theorem 2.1. The companion, Section 4.1, gives every estimate. Suppose $\mathcal{D}_p = N/K$, fix $p \in P$ and an index k with $q_k = p$, and let $t_m = t_k p^n$, so that $\theta_m = \theta_k + \Theta(n \log p)$. Dirichlet's simultaneous approximation theorem gives n for which this shift moves every crossing by less than a small ε . Cutting the positive

crossings of θ_k where consecutive ones are more than 2ε apart gives *chains*; $W(\theta_m)$ is the concatenation of the same chains in the same order, each rearranged, and a chain consists of at most $|P|$ distinct primes. The chains among the first ν crossings, with $2^\nu \geq K$, are single crossings, so Lemmas 2.3(ii) and 2.2 give $x_k = x_m$, and Lemma 2.3(i) gives $f(C) = f(C')$ for every chain C and its rearrangement C' . If $|P| \leq 3$, density of the differences $j \log p - i \log q$ gives a chain in which a p -crossing and a q -crossing change order, contradicting Lemma 2.4. If $|P| \geq 4$, a return of the orbit of θ_k near the point of Lemma 2.5, perturbed along the form $\theta_b - \theta_a$, which is nonzero on L , gives a chain $C = ab$ with $C' = ba$, and $f(ab) - f(ba) = b - a \neq 0$. $\square$

The companion's Section 11.1 compares $\mathcal{D}_P$, written as a Cantor series, with the criteria of Erdős–Straus [9], Hančl–Tijdeman [10] and Diananda and Oppenheim [8], none of which decides it.

2.1 The case $\{2, 3, 5\}$, checked in Lean

Theorem 2.6 (the distinct-height sum for $\{2, 3, 5\}$). *The number $\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}}$ is irrational.*

Lean

Checked in Lean for the sum exactly as defined in the introduction (Lean proof); Comparator has not yet been run on it. The constants of its proof, the five affine maps, their bounds and the gaps between their images, are also recomputed in exact arithmetic by the distinct-height programs.

The Lean proof takes a different route (companion, Sections 4.2 and 4.3): each dyadic block acts on the normalised tail by one of five affine maps with disjoint images, so a tail determines every later block, and a rational value would make the blocks eventually periodic, which the powers of 3 prevent. With an automaton recording how recently each prime appeared, the same method proves every set of three primes at most 31 by exact computation, and it fails for $\{2, 3, 5, 7\}$, where two words of blocks have the same affine map (companion, Sections 4.4 and 4.5).

3 Nonsingular minors of every order

Theorem 3.1 (no finite separation of the kernel). *Let p, q, r be primes with $p \neq q$, $p \neq r$ and $q \neq r$. For every $n \geq 0$ there are injective maps $I, J : \{0, \dots, n-1\} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$ such that, for every $k \geq 0$,*

Lean
Comparator

$$\det(K(I(a), J(b), k))_{0 \leq a, b < n} \neq 0.$$

Consequently, for no finite d do there exist rational-valued functions $f_\ell(i)$ and $G_\ell(j, k)$, $0 \leq \ell < d$, satisfying

$$K(i, j, k) = \sum_{\ell < d} f_\ell(i) G_\ell(j, k) \quad \text{for all } i, j, k.$$

Proof. For fixed k , we rescale rows and columns to obtain a matrix independent of k . Put $c = r^{-1}$, $x_i = \{i \log_r p\}$ and $y_j = \{j \log_r q\}$, where braces denote fractional parts. Splitting the floor exponents gives

$$K(i, j, k) = U_i(k)^{-1} C_{ij} V_j(k)^{-1}, \quad C_{ij} = c^{\mathbf{1}_{(x_i + y_j \geq 1)}},$$

where

$$U_i(k) = p^i q^{\lfloor \log_q(p^i r^k) \rfloor} r^{k + \lfloor \log_r p^i \rfloor},$$

$$V_j(k) = q^j p^{\lfloor \log_p(q^j r^k) \rfloor} r^{\lfloor \log_r q^j \rfloor}.$$

The positive factors do not affect whether a minor vanishes; C records only whether $x_i + y_j \geq 1$. Distinct primes make $\log_r p$ and $\log_r q$ irrational, so each fractional-part orbit is dense in $[0, 1]$. The row and column indices are independent choices; no density of a single orbit of pairs is required. For $n \geq 1$, choose distinct rows with $0 < x_{I(0)} < \dots < x_{I(n-1)} < 1$. We choose each column so that its entries change from 1 to c at a different selected row. Writing $s_b = 1 - y_{J(b)}$, density of (y_j) lets us choose

$$s_0 \in (0, x_{I(0)}), \quad s_b \in (x_{I(b-1)}, x_{I(b)}) \quad (1 \leq b < n).$$

The intervals for the s_b are disjoint, so the column indices are distinct. The strict inequalities also avoid the threshold itself, and give $x_{I(a)} + y_{J(b)} \geq 1$ exactly when $b \leq a$. Thus multiplying row a by $U_{I(a)}(k)$ and column b by $V_{J(b)}(k)$ reduces the selected kernel minor to

$$T_n(c) = \begin{pmatrix} c & 1 & \dots & 1 \\ c & c & \dots & 1 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ c & c & \dots & c \end{pmatrix}, \quad \det T_n(c) = c(c-1)^{n-1}.$$

Indeed, subtracting each preceding row from the next, working upwards from the last row, leaves diagonal entries $c, c-1, \dots, c-1$. The original determinant is therefore

$$c(c-1)^{n-1} \prod_{a < n} U_{I(a)}(k)^{-1} \prod_{b < n} V_{J(b)}(k)^{-1} \neq 0.$$

The indices were chosen from C , independently of k . For $n = 0$ the empty determinant equals 1.

For the final assertion, suppose a separation with d summands existed and fix any k . On the rows $I(0), \dots, I(d)$ and columns $J(0), \dots, J(d)$ its matrix would be the product of the $(d+1) \times d$ matrix $(f_\ell(I(a)))_{a,\ell}$ and the $d \times (d+1)$ matrix $(G_\ell(J(b), k))_{\ell,b}$. Its rank would be at most d , so its determinant would vanish, contrary to the minor just constructed. $\square$

No continuity or boundedness is assumed for the separated factors.

Corollary 3.2 (the same minors modulo integers coprime to 30). *For $(p, q, r) = (2, 3, 5)$ and every $n \geq 1$, there are injective maps $I, J : \{0, \dots, n-1\} \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$, chosen independently of B and k , such that for every $B \geq 2$ coprime to 30 and every $k \geq 0$, the selected $n \times n$ kernel matrix has unit determinant over $\mathbb{Z}/B\mathbb{Z}$, with each reciprocal prime power interpreted by its modular inverse.*

Lean
Comparator

Proof. Choose the maps from Theorem 3.1. Every row and column factor is a unit modulo B . The normalised determinant is $5^{-1}(-4/5)^{n-1}$, also a unit. $\square$

The modulus may be composite, for example 49 or 77. Coprimality with 30 makes both the reciprocal entries and the determinant units: the latter introduces only a power of 4 in its numerator.

Example 3.3. For $(p, q, r) = (2, 3, 5)$, the leading two-by-two determinant is $-1/15$: its four entries are $1, 1/6, 1/2, 1/60$, so it equals $1/60 - 1/12$.

The indices must be selected. The leading 4×4 block at $\{2, 3, 5\}$ is singular:

$$K(3, j, 0) = \frac{1}{120} K(0, j, 0) \quad (0 \leq j < 4).$$

These equalities follow by evaluating the height at 3^j and $8 \cdot 3^j$. But at $j = 4$, $K(3, 4, 0) - K(0, 4, 0)/120 = -1/19440000$. Thus the leading minors do not supply the arbitrary-order theorem.

Proposition 3.4 (rank of a matrix of threshold columns). *Let $m \geq 1$ and let c lie in a field with $c \neq 0, 1$. For $0 \leq k \leq m$ write v_k for the length- m column with a 1 in each of the first k coordinates and c thereafter. A matrix whose distinct columns are v_k for k in a nonempty set E has rank $|E| - \mathbf{1}_{\{0, m\} \subseteq E}$.*

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The correction accounts for the two constant columns: $v_0 = cv_m$. There is no other dependence among distinct threshold columns.

Proof. List $E = \{k_1 < \dots < k_t\}$. The $t - 1$ differences $v_{k_{j+1}} - v_{k_j} = (1 - c)\mathbf{1}_{\{k_j, \dots, k_{j+1}-1\}}$ have disjoint nonempty supports, hence are linearly independent. If $k_1 > 0$ or $k_t < m$, their union misses a coordinate where v_{k_1} is nonzero, so the rank is t . If $k_1 = 0$ and $k_t = m$, then $v_0 = c\mathbf{1}$ lies in the span of the differences (their sum is $(1 - c)\mathbf{1}$), so the rank is $t - 1$. $\square$

The restrictions $c \neq 0, 1$ exclude a zero column or identical columns; they hold for $c = 1/r$ over $\mathbb{Q}$. In one fixed layer k , ordering the sampled row phases puts every column in the stated form. The formula therefore determines the rank of each nonempty rectangular sample. For fixed row and column indices this rank is independent of k . Section 5 of the companion paper, *The Three-Prime Running LCM: Kernel Rank and Tail Arithmetic*, gives the exact rational comparisons.

Exact rank is not an approximation obstruction. Truncating the original kernel to $i < N$ gives a sum of N separated terms. The bound $H(x) > x^3/(pqr)$ makes the truncation error tend to zero both uniformly and in $\ell^1(\mathbb{N}^3)$. By contrast, the rescaled matrix in the rank proof has uniform distance $(1 - 1/r)/2$ from the matrices of finite rank. Rescaling preserves exact rank but removes the decay responsible for the first approximation. The companion proves both assertions, including the distinction between finite restrictions and the full infinite matrix, in Section 5.1.

4 The two-prime comparison

Fan's post of 26 June 2026 gives the repeated two-prime factorisation, its quadratic expression in one Hecke–Mahler value and its transcendence conclusion [7]. Counting the contributions at powers of each prime also gives the affine formula for the distinct-height sum below. The calculation fixes the normalisations and distinguishes the two sums.

Theorem 4.1 (both two-prime sums). *Let $p < q$ be distinct primes. Put $\theta = \log p / \log q$ and $A = \sum_{n \geq 0} p^{-n} q^{-\lfloor n\theta \rfloor}$. Let $\mathcal{R}_{p,q}$ sum the reciprocal running LCM at every positive $\{p, q\}$ -smooth integer, and let $\mathcal{D}_{p,q}$ count each distinct running LCM once. Then*

Lean[†]

$$\mathcal{D}_{p,q} = \frac{(q-p)A + p}{q-1}, \quad \mathcal{R}_{p,q} = \frac{(p+q-1)A - (p-1)A^2}{q-1}. \quad (2)$$

Both numbers are transcendental.

The Lean proof assumes the transcendence theorem of Bugeaud and Laurent; the two identities in (2) are proved in Lean without it.

Proof. Set $x = 1/p$, $y = 1/q$, $m_n = \lfloor n\theta \rfloor$ and $\delta_n = m_{n+1} - m_n$. Unique factorisation makes θ irrational, and $0 < \theta < 1$ gives $\delta_n \in \{0, 1\}$. The initial value and the positive powers of p contribute $A = \sum_{n \geq 0} x^n y^{m_n}$. There is one q -power strictly between p^n and p^{n+1} exactly when $\delta_n = 1$, so the positive powers of q contribute

$$B = \sum_{n \geq 0} \delta_n x^n y^{m_{n+1}}, \quad \mathcal{D}_{p,q} = A + B.$$

Since $0 < x, y < 1$, these series converge absolutely. The identity $y^{m_{n+1}} - y^{m_n} = \delta_n y^{m_n} (y - 1)$ and an index shift in A give $A - 1 - xA = x(y - 1)B/y$. Therefore

$$B = \frac{p - (p-1)A}{q-1}.$$

At $p^i q^j$ the height is $p^{i+\lfloor j/\theta \rfloor} q^{j+m_i}$, hence

$$\mathcal{R}_{p,q} = A \sum_{j \geq 0} y^j x^{\lfloor j/\theta \rfloor} = A(1 + B).$$

For the last equality, each $j \geq 1$ corresponds to $n = \lfloor j/\theta \rfloor$ with $m_n = j - 1$ and $\delta_n = 1$. These identities prove (2).

For the Hecke–Mahler series $F_\theta(x, y) = \sum_{n \geq 1} \sum_{k=1}^{m_n} x^n y^k$, geometric summation gives

$$A = \frac{1}{1-x} - \frac{1-y}{y} F_\theta(x, y). \quad (3)$$

Bugeaud and Laurent’s theorem [5, Theorem 1.1] applies with intercept $\rho = 0$, $\beta = x$ and $\alpha = y$: the slope θ is irrational and lies in $(0, 1)$, x and y are nonzero algebraic numbers, $|x| < 1$ and $|xy^\theta| = p^{-2} < 1$. Hence $F_\theta(x, y)$ is transcendental; this case $\rho = 0$ is due to Loxton and van der Poorten [6, Theorem 8, p. 40]. Thus A is transcendental. The displayed affine and quadratic polynomials are nonconstant, so an algebraic value of either would force A to be algebraic. $\square$

The same calculation applies to the monoid generated by any coprime integers $1 < p < q$, such as 4, 9, but need not describe all integers supported on their prime factors. The companion’s Section 3 gives this extension and the failure for 4, 8.

The distinct-height sums for every finite set of primes were treated in Section 2. The tail argument of the next two sections starts again from the running LCM and retains every multiplicity; it does not use the rank theorem.

5 The recurrence for the repeated sum

Proposition 5.1 (the running least common multiple). *Let p, q, r be pairwise distinct primes and $x \geq 1$. Then the running LCM equals the three-prime height: $L(x) = H(x)$.*

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Proof. Every smooth $n \leq x$ has prime exponents bounded by the corresponding integer logarithms, so $n \mid H(x)$. Conversely the three maximal pure powers occur among those smooth numbers; their product divides the running LCM because they are pairwise coprime. $\square$

The inequalities $x/p < p^{\lfloor \log_p x \rfloor} \leq x$ for each of the three primes also give

$$x^3/(pqr) < H(x) \leq x^3. \quad (4)$$

Proposition 5.2 (cells and jumps). *The running LCM is constant when the three integer logarithms are constant. A jump in exactly one logarithm multiplies it by the corresponding prime. The first n positive powers of each prime, together with 1, form $3n + 1$ distinct points.*

[Lean](#)
[Comparator](#)

Proof. The first two claims follow from the height formula. Positive powers of different primes cannot coincide, by unique factorisation, and none is 1. $\square$

For $(p, q, r) = (2, 3, 5)$ the smooth numbers 5 and 6 share the height 60, as noted in the introduction. The next identity retains such multiplicities when equal heights are grouped.

Proposition 5.3 (grouping terms with the same height). *For a finite exponent box $\mathcal{B}$, set $F(H) = \{(i, j, k) \in \mathcal{B} : H(p^i q^j r^k) = H\}$. Then*

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$$\sum_{(i,j,k) \in \mathcal{B}} K(i, j, k) = \sum_H \frac{\#F(H)}{H}. \quad (5)$$

Proof. Each term in $F(H)$ equals $1/H$. The multiplicities remain present in every subsequent infinite sum. $\square$

From now on let $P = \{2, 3, 5\}$ and $S = \mathcal{R}_P$. For $a \geq 0$ define

$$s_a = \sum_{\substack{x \text{ smooth} \\ 2^a \leq x < 2^{a+1}}} \frac{1}{H(x)}, \quad T_a = \sum_{j \geq 0} s_{a+j}, \quad h_a = \frac{H(2^a)}{2}, \quad X_a = h_a T_a.$$

The half-height h_a clears the finite prefix: for $a \geq 1$ and smooth $x < 2^a$, the exponent of 2 in $H(x)$ is at most $a - 1$, so $H(x) \mid H(2^a)/2$. This is why we omit the final factor 2. Here $h_0 = 1/2$; only for $a \geq 1$ is h_a an integer. Define

$$b_a = \frac{H(2^{a+1})}{H(2^a)}, \quad m_a = \sum_{\substack{x \text{ smooth} \\ 2^a \leq x < 2^{a+1}}} \frac{H(2^{a+1})}{2H(x)}. \quad (6)$$

Lemma 5.4 (integer coefficients and four possible bases). *For every $a \geq 0$, m_a is a positive integer and $b_a \in \{2, 6, 10, 30\}$. The word “numerator” does not impose the positional-digit restriction $m_a < b_a$; that restriction need not hold.*

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Proof. If $x < 2^{a+1}$, the exponent of 2 in $H(x)$ is at most a , while the other exponents are bounded by those of $H(2^{a+1})$. Hence $2H(x) \mid H(2^{a+1})$. Each summand is an integer, and the shell contains 2^a . Between consecutive powers of 2 there is at most one power of 3 and at most one power of 5: successive powers of either odd prime have ratio greater than two. These factors, when present, and the factor 2 at the right endpoint give the four possible bases. $\square$

In the shell $[2, 4)$ the terms $1/2$ and $1/6$, with $h_2 = b_1 = 6$, give $m_1 = 4$ and the recurrence $X_2 = 6X_1 - 4$. The shell $[16, 32)$ shows why these numerators are not positional digits: $m_4 = 65 > b_4 = 30$. The companion computes the carried digits separately.

Proposition 5.5 (the tail recurrence and a quadratic bound). *The series defining S, T_a converge. For every $a \geq 0$,*

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$$X_{a+1} = b_a X_a - m_a, \quad 0 < X_a \leq \frac{8640}{343}(a+1)^2 < 90(a+1)^2.$$

For every integer $B \geq 1$, either some BX_a is integral and all later states are integral, or $\text{dist}(BX_a, \mathbb{Z}) \geq 1/31$ at arbitrarily large indices.

Proof. For each pair of exponents of 3 and 5, at most one exponent of 2 places the smooth integer in $[2^a, 2^{a+1})$. The two odd-prime exponents lie between 0 and a , giving at most $(a+1)^2$ terms. By (4), $s_a \leq 30(a+1)^2/8^a$. Since $h_a \leq 8^a/2$ and $a+j+1 \leq (a+1)(j+1)$ for $a, j \geq 0$, summing the later shells gives

$$X_a \leq 15(a+1)^2 \sum_{j \geq 0} \frac{(j+1)^2}{8^j} = \frac{8640}{343}(a+1)^2.$$

This proves convergence and the bound. Splitting the first shell gives the recurrence because $m_a = h_{a+1}s_a$ and $h_{a+1} = b_a h_a$. If all sufficiently late distances are strictly below $1/31$, write $BX_a = z_a + e_a$ with $z_a \in \mathbb{Z}$ and $|e_a| < 1/31$. Since Bm_a is integral, $e_{a+1} - b_a e_a$ is an integer of absolute value less than $(1 + b_a)/31 \leq 1$, so $e_{a+1} = b_a e_a$. The lower bound $b_a \geq 2$ forces this bounded error to vanish; integrality then propagates by the recurrence. $\square$

The identity $S/2 = \sum_{a \geq 0} m_a / (b_0 \cdots b_a)$ places the recurrence in the setting of Cantor series. The classical criteria of Erdős–Straus [9, Theorem 2.1] and Hančl–Tijdeman [10, Theorem 3.1] require $m_a / (b_{a-1} b_a) \rightarrow 0$. That hypothesis fails here: the numerators grow quadratically while the bases are bounded. The companion’s Section 7 proves the growth assertion and gives the precise carry conditions. The argument below instead uses the recurrence and the proved bound $90B(a+1)^2$ directly.

Theorem 5.6 (rationality gives positive integer tails). *If $S = A/D$ in lowest terms, where $D = 2^u 3^v 5^w B$ and $\gcd(B, 30) = 1$, then for every $a \geq a_0 = u + 1 + 2v + 3w$,*

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$$d_a = BX_a \in \mathbb{Z}_{>0}, \quad d_{a+1} = b_a d_a - Bm_a, \quad d_a \leq 90B(a+1)^2.$$

Proof. For $a \geq 1$, every $H(x)$ with $x < 2^a$ divides h_a . Subtracting the finite prefix therefore gives

$$X_a = h_a S - \sum_{\substack{x \text{ smooth} \\ x < 2^a}} \frac{h_a}{H(x)}, \quad \sum_{\substack{x \text{ smooth} \\ x < 2^a}} \frac{h_a}{H(x)} \in \mathbb{Z}. \quad (7)$$

The exponent of 2 in h_a is $a - 1$. Moreover $a \geq 2v$ gives $2^a \geq 3^v$, and $a \geq 3w$ gives $2^a \geq 5^w$. Thus $2^u 3^v 5^w \mid h_a$ after the stated onset, and BX_a differs from $h_a A / (2^u 3^v 5^w)$ by an integer and is therefore integral. Positivity, the recurrence and the bound follow from Proposition 5.5. $\square$

Every positive denominator splits in the required way: B is what remains after removing all factors 2, 3 and 5. For example, a hypothetical reduced denominator $2^3 3^2 5 \cdot 7$ would give $B = 7$; the next result gives the first integral $7X_a$ at $a = 4$, whereas the sufficient bound above gives $a_0 = 11$.

Corollary 5.7 (the first index at which the denominator clears). *Under the same lowest-terms hypothesis, put $M = 2^u 3^v 5^w$ and let den denote the positive reduced denominator. For $a \geq 1$,*

$$\text{den}(BX_a) = \frac{M}{\gcd(M, h_a)}.$$

Consequently BX_a is integral exactly when $2^a \geq \max(2^{u+1}, 3^v, 5^w)$. The first such a can be found by integer comparisons, without logarithmic rounding.

Proof. By (7), BX_a differs from $h_a A / M$ by an integer. Since $\gcd(A, M) = 1$, reducing that fraction gives the displayed denominator. The three divisibility conditions for h_a are precisely the three inequalities stated above. $\square$

The companion's Section 4.6 shows where the dyadic and two-tail arguments stop for the repeated sum, whose scaled tails are unbounded.

The comparison does close on part of the catalogue series. For $p \in P$ let $E_p = \sum_{\alpha \geq 0} L(p^\alpha)^{-1}$ be the sub-sum of $\mathcal{R}_P$ over the powers of p . Then $\mathcal{D}_P = \sum_{q \in P} E_q - (|P| - 1)$, and for two primes $\mathcal{R}_{\{p, q\}} = E_p E_q$, which is the factorisation in the proof of Theorem 4.1.

Theorem 5.8 (the single-prime sub-sums). *For every finite set P of primes with $|P| \geq 2$ and every $p \in P$, the number E_p is irrational.*

Ordinary proof in the companion, Section 4.6. It was found within this project on 26 September 2026 and checked step by step by a second, independent AI agent; it has had no human review and has no Lean proof, so Comparator does not apply. For $|P| = 2$, E_p is an affine function of the Hecke–Mahler value in the proof of Theorem 4.1 and is transcendental. For $|P| \geq 3$ we have not searched the literature.

The proof compares the tails after p^α and $p^{\alpha+n}$ as in Section 2, with the invariant replaced by the product of the primes that follow p in a run, and takes the run at a passage of the flow near the origin of the torus; no two-wall lemma is needed. For $\mathcal{R}_P$ itself the comparison fails at its first step: between the two scales the tail of $\mathcal{R}_P$ gains the early terms of every ray $p^\alpha w$, with w a $(P \setminus \{p\})$ -smooth integer, that enters there, and E_p is the case $w = 1$, where nothing enters.

6 A window test and the remaining arithmetic

Two steps of the recurrence already show the finite data we need:

$$X_{\ell+2} = b_{\ell+1}b_{\ell}X_{\ell} - (b_{\ell+1}m_{\ell} + m_{\ell+1}).$$

If BX_{ℓ} is an integer, this identity determines the residue of $BX_{\ell+2}$ modulo the product of the two bases. We will compare the least positive representative of that residue with the upper bound for the endpoint tail.

For a window starting at $\ell \geq 0$ and having $h \geq 0$ steps, define its product of bases and accumulated numerator from (6) by

$$W_{\ell,0} = 1, \quad F_{\ell,0} = 0, \quad W_{\ell,h+1} = b_{\ell+h}W_{\ell,h}, \quad F_{\ell,h+1} = b_{\ell+h}F_{\ell,h} + m_{\ell+h}.$$

Induction on h gives

$$X_{\ell+h} = W_{\ell,h}X_{\ell} - F_{\ell,h}. \quad (8)$$

For integers $W \geq 1$ and t , define $\text{lpr}_W(t) = 1 + ((t - 1) \bmod W)$, using a remainder in $\{0, \dots, W - 1\}$. Thus a zero residue is represented by W , not 0. Throughout this section use the upper bound

$$K(B, a) = 90B(a + 1)^2. \quad (9)$$

Lemma 6.1 (least positive residues). *If d is a positive integer with $d \leq K$ and $d \equiv -BF \pmod{W}$, where $W \geq 1$, then $\text{lpr}_W(-BF) \leq K$.*

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Proof. Every positive representative of the residue is at least its least positive representative, so $\text{lpr}_W(-BF) \leq d \leq K$. $\square$

For example, the window starting at $\ell = 1$ with length 6 has $W_{1,6} = 648000$ and $F_{1,6} = 524431$. At $B = 1$ its least positive residue is 123569, exceeding $K(1, 7) = 5760$. This rules out an integral X_1 , but not a rational denominator that would clear only at a later index. The theorem therefore asks for windows beyond every prescribed starting index, as well as for every eligible denominator.

Theorem 6.2 (a residue criterion for irrationality). *The number S is irrational if and only if*

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$$\begin{aligned} &\text{for every } B \geq 1 \text{ with } \gcd(B, 30) = 1 \text{ and every } a_0 \geq 1, \\ &\text{there are } \ell \geq a_0, h \geq 1 \text{ such that } \text{lpr}_{W_{\ell,h}}(-BF_{\ell,h}) > K(B, \ell + h). \end{aligned} \quad (10)$$

Proof. Assume (10) and suppose S is rational. Theorem 5.6 supplies a positive integral carry $d_a = BX_a$ after its onset. Choose a window in (10) beyond that onset. Equation (8) gives $d_{\ell+h} \equiv -BF_{\ell,h} \pmod{W_{\ell,h}}$, contradicting Lemma 6.1 and the upper bound.

Conversely, let S be irrational and fix $B, \ell \geq 1$. Equation (7) makes BX_{ℓ} nonintegral. Put $\delta = [BX_{\ell}] - BX_{\ell} \in (0, 1)$. Since $W_{\ell,h} \geq 2^h$ and $X_{\ell+h} = O((\ell + h + 1)^2)$, for all sufficiently large h the number $\delta + BX_{\ell+h}/W_{\ell,h}$ lies in $(0, 1)$. The window identity shows that the integer $[BX_{\ell}]W_{\ell,h} - BF_{\ell,h}$ lies strictly between 0 and $W_{\ell,h}$ and is congruent to $-BF_{\ell,h}$. Hence

$$\text{lpr}_{W_{\ell,h}}(-BF_{\ell,h}) = \delta W_{\ell,h} + BX_{\ell+h}.$$

Its exponentially growing first term eventually exceeds $K(B, \ell + h)$. This proves (10), in fact from each fixed start. $\square$

The proved bound $90B(a+1)^2$ controls every positive integral BX_a that rationality would force. Polynomial growth alone does not suffice: the zero bound would make the residue inequality automatic. The companion, Section 8, treats smaller and more general bounds. No finite search establishes the unbounded quantifiers in (10).

The remaining task has the following three equivalent formulations.

Problem 6.3 (the repeated three-prime target). Prove that $S = \mathcal{R}_{\{2,3,5\}}$ is irrational.

Problem 6.4 (no reduced tail is an integer). Prove that for every $a \geq 1$ and every integer $B \geq 1$ coprime to 30,

$$BX_a \notin \mathbb{Z}. \quad (11)$$

Problem 6.5 (residue inequalities after every starting index). Prove (10).

Indeed, one integral scaled tail makes S rational by (7), whereas denominator clearing gives such tails from a rational S . Theorem 6.2 supplies the third equivalence. These arithmetic assertions remain unproved. The companion's finite certificates (Section 9) and its comparisons with other approaches (Section 10) are supplementary; the argument here does not rely on them.

Statements and declarations

Proof sources. Theorem 4.1 uses the transcendence theorem of Bugeaud and Laurent, which its Lean proof assumes. Fan's post of 26 June 2026 on the erdosproblems.com forum has priority for the two-prime deduction [7]. Theorem 2.1 and Lemmas 2.2–2.5 have ordinary proofs, outlined in Section 2 and given in full in the companion, Section 4.1, and no Lean proofs; a formal proof would need Kronecker's theorem on the closure of a line in a torus and the Euler characteristic count of Lemma 2.5. The proof of Theorem 2.1 was found by an AI agent on 26 September 2026 and checked by a second AI agent working independently, who re-derived every step and closed five small gaps; it has had no human review. Theorem 5.8 has the ordinary proof in the companion, checked in the same way, and no Lean proof. Theorem 2.6 is checked in Lean, as the remark below it states; Comparator has not yet compared it. Every other theorem, proposition, lemma and corollary has a Lean proof of its whole statement, marked in the margin; Appendix A describes the formal sources. Neither these proofs nor the finite calculations supply the required windows for every eligible denominator and arbitrarily late starts.

Artefact and data availability. The companion contains the detailed bounds and supplementary arguments; its source inventory explains the normalisation conventions of the Lean sources. The [distinct-height programs](#) recompute the constants of Theorem 2.6 and the companion's three- and four-prime certificates in exact rational arithmetic, and store their outputs; the same directory holds exact illustrations of the proof of Theorem 2.1, which the proof does not use. AI agents carried out most of the research and drafting. The work has not had independent human mathematical review.

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A Guide to the formal sources

There are four separate arguments. The proof of Theorem 2.1 uses integral tails, rearranged blocks, a closed subtorus and an Euler characteristic count, and has no Lean proof. The proof of Theorem 2.6 uses dyadic blocks, the disjoint images of five affine maps and the irrationality of $\log 2 / \log 3$; its Lean proof follows the same route. The rank proof uses the height formula, row and column rescaling, and a threshold determinant. The arithmetic argument uses the shell coefficients, the tail recurrence, denominator clearing and least positive residues. The Lean proof of Theorem 6.2 establishes the equivalence of the residue condition with irrationality; it does not establish the residue condition itself.

Library declarations. The margin marks link each result to its Lean proof. The main steps rest on the following library declarations, each opened at a fixed revision. Distinct heights: the height is the running LCM; the sum counts each distinct value once; a power of 5 in every three consecutive blocks; the blocks containing a power of 3 are not eventually periodic; the criterion for the five block letters; the irrationality of $\mathcal{D}_{\{2,3,5\}}$. Running LCM: the exact height formula; constancy on each logarithmic cell; the jumps by p , q and r ; exactly 3 count + 1 jump values; the quadratic bound on exponent shells. Dyadic blocks: at most one internal pure-power jump per channel; the radix is 2, 6, 10 or 30; the radix lies in $[2, 30]$. Kernel rank: the kernel is not of rank one; the smallest 2×2 minor equals $-1/15$; the tail-state recurrence. Residues and carries: no bounded positive state represents an escaping residue (integer form); the local-window escape condition and its exclusion of a positive reduced carry; a bounded-radix orbit is integral or cofinally far from the integers; no uniformly bounded nonzero carry lift; block-null words are channel coboundaries; the carry as a residue digit plus a coboundary; a finite-dimensional factorisation gives a finite realised span.

Scope of the supplementary literature. The companion develops the comparisons omitted from the main argument. Its Section 6 relates the bounded-ratio argument to Erdős–Taylor [11, Theorem 1, p. 600] and Fan [12, Lemma 3.1, p. 7]; Section 7 compares the exact carry restrictions and polynomial-radix assumptions of Hančl–Tijdeman [13, Theorems 2.2, 3.1 and 4.2]. The Isabelle development of Koutsoukou–Argyrazi and Li [19] verifies classical criteria, not the present series.

Section 10 of the companion separates the finite-difference hypotheses of Luca–Ouaknine–Worrell [14, Definition 5, Theorems 6 and 8, Claim 10] from quadratic growth alone, and checks the obstacles to using the echoing [15], digit-complexity [20, Theorem 1] and multivariate Mahler [21] results. These comparisons do not establish the missing hypotheses for S .

For broader background, the companion distinguishes work on fixed-prime semi-groups [16, 17] from other unit-fraction irrationality problems [18]. No estimate from those papers is used in this note’s counting argument.

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